The Dance of Life and Red is the Color of Blood

By Conrad Aiken

INTRODUCTION

Conrad Aiken grew up in a household with parents who constantly argued. His father was a physician with a struggling practice and his mother was a wanna-be socialite who loved to entertain. This marital discord ended when Aiken was only eleven years old. He found the bodies of his parents - his father, brilliant but unstable, had killed his mother and committed suicide. Aiken struggled with this tragedy, battling to keep his depression at bay; however he confessed in his later years that he "found himself possessed of them forever." The Dance of Life is his tribute to the memory of his parents, and quite possibly a form of self-therapy.

The Dance of Life

Gracious and lovable and sweet,

She made his jaded pulses beat,

And made the glare of streets grow dim

And life more soft and hushed for him....

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Over her shoulder now she smiled

Trustfully to him, like a child,

The while her fingers gayly moved

Along these white keys dearly loved,

Making them laugh a jocund measure,

Making them show and sing her pleasure....

A smile that dwelt upon his eyes,

To see what mood might therein rise,--

What point of soft light seen afar

Which might dilate to moon or star....

A smile that for a second space

Brooded wistfully on her face,

Opening soft her spirit's door,

Disclosing depths undreamed before:

Passionate depths of half-seen flame,

Young loveliness despising shame,

Desire that trembled to meet desire,

And fire that yearned to fuse with fire....

And lightly then she turned away,

Ironic music rippled gay,--

Subtle sarcastic flippancies

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Disguising speechless ecstasies...
"Play something else..." He rose to turn
The pages, while the deep nocturne
Struck slow rich chords of plangent pain,
Beautiful, into heart and brain;
A tortured, anguished, suffering thing
That seemed at once to cry and sing;
Despairing love that strove to find
The face beloved with fingers blind.
He saw her body's slender grace,
This drooping shoulder, shadowed face;
All of her body, hidden so
In saffron satin's flush and flow,--
Its white and simple loveliness,--
Came on his heart like giddiness,
Seductive as this music came;
Until her body seemed like flame,--
Intense white flame, so swiftly moving
That it gave scarcely time for loving;
But rapid as the sun she seemed,
A blinding light that flowed and streamed

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And sang and shone through roaring space....
The sun itself! for now her face,
Wherein this music's whole soul dwelt,
Drew him like helpless star, he felt
A fierce compulsion, reckless, mad,
A sweet compulsion, troubled, glad,
His trembling hands went out to her,
Her cool flesh made his senses blur;
While, head thrown backward, sinking dim,
She opened wide her soul to him....
Past his life went whirls of lights,
Chaos of music, days and nights,
Her wild eyes yearned to lure him in
And close him up in dark of sin,
To lure him in and drink him down
And all his soul in love to drown....
Her nakedness he seemed to see.
And breast to breast, and knee to knee,
Tremulous, breathless, swaying, burning,
Body to beautiful body yearning,
In joy and terror, flesh to flesh,

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They flamed in passion's fine red mesh,--

Living in one short breath again

The cosmic tide's whole bliss and pain,

Darkness and ether, nebulous fire,

Vast suns whirled forth by vast desire,

Huge moons flung out with monstrous mirth

And stars in glorious hells of birth,

All jubilating, blazing, reeling,

An orgiastic splendor wheeling,

Moon torn from earth and star from sun

In screaming pain, titanic fun,

And stars whirled back to sun again

To be consumed in flaming pain!...

In them at last all life was met:

They were God's self! This earth had set.

Mad fires of life sang through their veins,

Ruinous blisses, joyous pains,

Life the destroyer, life the breaker,

And death, the everlasting maker....

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Conrad Aiken
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TRANSITION

And while it is true that every life ends in death; Conrad Aiken demonstrates a fascination with the concept in a wide variety of his published works. Undoubtedly the trauma he witnessed as a child influenced his creativity throughout his life. In Red is the Color of Blood, Aiken seems to take on the persona of his own father in contemplating the thoughts that led up to his mother's murder.

Red is the Color of Blood

Red is the color of blood, and I will seek it:

I have sought it in the grass.

It is the color of steep sun seen through eyelids.

It is hidden under the suave flesh of women--

Flows there, quietly flows.

It mounts from the heart to the temples, the singing

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mouth--
As cold sap climbs to the rose.
I am confused in webs and knots of scarlet
Spun from the darkness;
Or shuttled from the mouths of thirsty spiders.

Madness for red! I devour the leaves of autumn.
I tire of the green of the world.
I am myself a mouth for blood ...

Here, in the golden haze of the late slant sun,
Let us walk, with the light in our eyes,
To a single bench from the outset predetermined.
Look: there are seagulls in these city skies,
Kindled against the blue.
But I do not think of the seagulls, I think of you.

Your eyes, with the late sun in them,
Are like blue pools dazzled with yellow petals.
This pale green suits them well.

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Here is your finger, with an emerald on it:
The one I gave you. I say these things politely--
But what I think beneath them, who can tell?

For I think of you, crumpled against a whiteness;
Flayed and torn, with a dulled face.
I think of you, writing, a thing of scarlet,
And myself, rising red from that embrace.

November sun is sunlight poured through honey:
Old things, in such a light, grow subtle and fine.
Bare oaks are like still fire.
Talk to me: now we drink the evening's wine.
Look, how our shadows creep along the grave!--
And this way, how the gravel begins to shine!

This is the time of day for recollections,
For sentimental regrets, oblique allusions,
Rose-leaves, shriveled in a musty jar.
Scatter them to the wind! There are tempests coming.
It is dark, with a windy star.

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If human mouths were really roses, my dear,--

(Why must we link things so?--)

I would tear yours petal by petal with slow murder.

I would pluck the stamens, the pistils,

The gold and the green,--

Spreading the subtle sweetness that was your breath

On a cold wave of death....

Now let us walk back, slowly, as we came.

We will light the room with candles; they may shine

Like rows of yellow eyes.

Your hair is like spun fire, by candle-flame.

You smile at me--say nothing. You are wise.

For I think of you, flung down brutal darkness;

Crushed and red, with pale face.

I think of you, with your hair disordered and dripping.

And myself, rising red from that embrace.

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